

ISYS90045 Professional IS Consulting

Seminar 6 Professional Advice Report Writing

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Learning Objectives

Agenda

Define and understand consulting communication techniques

- ▶ Report writing
- ▶ Workshops

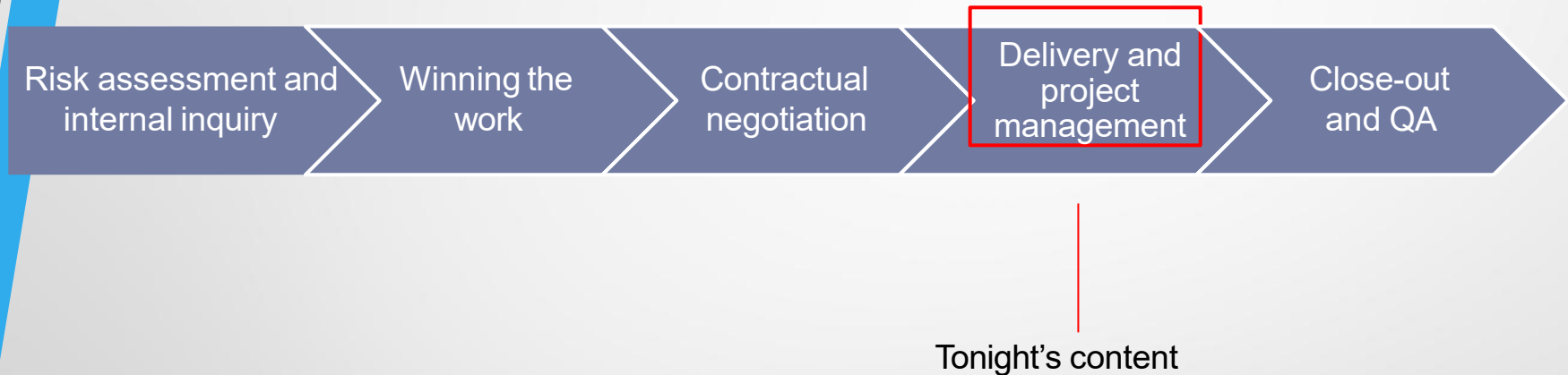
And next week

- ▶ Meetings
- ▶ Interviews



Engagement Lifecycle

How is work won and performed in consultancies?



Reporting

We perform a lot of reporting

- ▶ Shorter status reports on
 - ▶ Requirements
 - ▶ Design
 - ▶ Development
 - ▶ Testing

Reporting is key for

- ▶ gap analyses
- ▶ feasibility studies
- ▶ internal audits

Reports are often:

- ▶ The one tangible thing the client will have from you when you leave
- ▶ Is your set of answers to the problem being solved
- ▶ Could be the starting point for transforming your client.

The basic rule for reports

Put yourself in the client's place:

What do they want to know?

How much information/ detail do they need?

Are they paying for this?

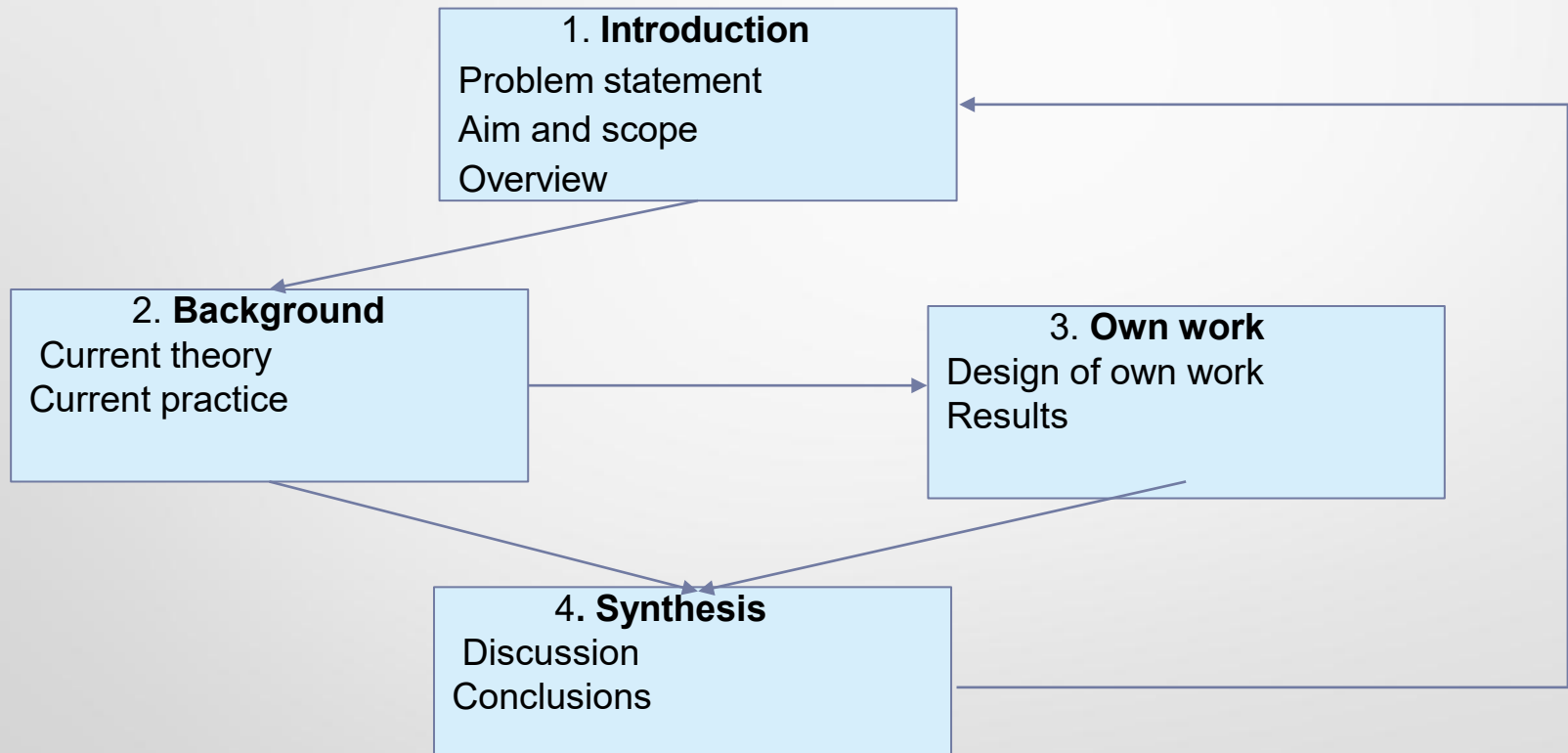
A simple report format

- **Table of Contents**

- Executive Summary (one page)
- Introduction: Statement of key questions and the context in which they were asked
- Your approach: How did you do the work?
- Answers to key questions
 - Include reasons and brief summary of alternatives
 - Findings and recommendations
 - Roadmap?
- Appendices: interview notes, calculations etc.

A simple report format

Consider how theses are structured (Evans and Gruba, 2005)



Source: Evans, D. and Gruba, P. (2005) *How to write a better thesis*, 2nd Edition, Melbourne University Press.

Advice

- ✓ Summarise first – verbally:
 - ▶ “What are you trying to say?”
 - ▶ One sentence
 - ▶ Then expand
 - ▶ Get feedback from partner
 - ▶ Repeat until satisfied!
- ✓ Write the summary
- ✓ List your key points
- ✓ Organise into a structure
- ✓ Find the best way to communicate each key message (graph, table, words)
- ✓ Write the report
- ✓ Re-write the summary
- ✓ Let it rest for a while
- ✓ Review and re-write

Advice from the experts

Your introduction

- ▶ Clearly articulate your problem statement(s)
- ▶ Present your aim – and ensure this is achieved
- ▶ Cover off scope (what's in, what's out?)
- ▶ Provide overview of the rest of the structure

Results, discussion, recommendations

- ▶ Consider your section introductions and concluding statements/ key points – write these down in order. Do they make sense?
- ▶ Acknowledge limitations of your findings through referencing your scope
- ▶ Any results should be mapped against theory/ experience or a core framework (reliability of outcomes).

Source: Evans, D. and Gruba, P. (2005) *How to write a better thesis*, 2nd Edition, Melbourne University Press.

Let's review a report



Exercise 15 Minutes

ACS Digital Pulse 2025

- Search online ACS Digital Pulse 2025
- Complete the form and download
- In groups review the report

Tip = Benchmark against the Table of Contents on Slide 7

- What is the report about?
- Who is it written for?
- Assess how well the report conveys its message
- What techniques are used?

https://www.acs.org.au/campaign/digital-pulse.html?gad_source=1&gad_campaignid=22968846846&gbraid=0AAAABBSm7cgrK0WUcCkrX6o8L8b9UuCP&gclid=CjwKCAjw2vTFBhAuEiwAFaScwhaebxljaSnd_LLXjgtlrPadGl64KBdquMntWUAvuWxz8XJsmy4exoCDUIQAvD_BwE



Common mistakes in reports

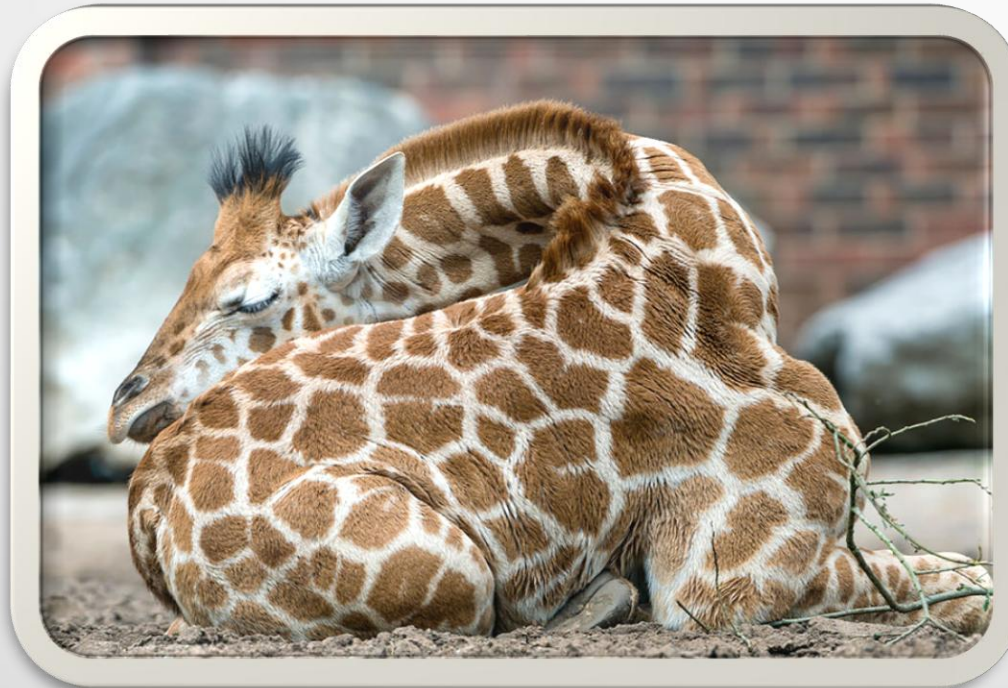
- × “What I did in my holidays”
- × Patronising information
- × Demonstrating knowledge
- × Delivering by weight
- × Unnecessary effort and expense
- × Not re-checking the brief
- × And... problems with expectations...
- × Introducing new material in the conclusion
- × Having a ‘conclusion’ at all
- × Overly-complex diagrams, tables, images
- × Sharing all your thinking
- × Poor grammar and spelling
- × Inappropriate content

Summary

This seminar has explored methods of communicating as a consultant

- Explore structured communication styles
- Define and understand the role of report writing
- Define the role of meetings in consulting
- Identify meeting success factors
- Explore the role of Interviews and workshops

A little rest



10 mins